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Q Why should an Ubuntu user switch to Fedora?

Because Fedora tries to be very friendly from the free and open source perspective. For example, when you search in a Fedora search box in Firefox, all of that is going to the search engine company that you are using. It doesn't go anywhere else. We respect the freedom of people, so we do not lock anyone into anything. We also respect the laws of the land. For example, the ability to playback an MP3 file is not available, by default, in Fedora. There are certain restrictions to what can and cannot be done from the Fedora perspective because software like MP3 is only available on certain royalty. Being a free distribution and a free of charge distribution like Fedora, this is going to be very difficult for us to do. But that doesn't stop the end-user from installing an MP3 player to be able to listen to music.

However, I would like to add that if everything in a distro is suitable and working for a user, he should continue using it. He should not change just for the sake of changing. He should change only if he wants to explore something new or try something different and see what that entails for him. You don't have to install a distro on your system in order to try it. You can try it on a live CD or run it on a virtual machine to test it out.

Everything said, both Ubuntu and Fedora are evolving rapidly in many ways. In most cases, the last thing an end user wants to do is to shell out a lot of money for the operating system. Therefore, open source operating systems make a lot of difference. Frankly, the whole idea of cloud computing will bring in a lot of changes in the way people think. The OS running on the desktop will not have much significance in the times to come. It is going to be more browser oriented, which would require a very high-speed network connection. When it comes to the cloud, whether it is public, private or hybrid, the desktop and OS are of little or no consequence. What you need is a high-quality secure browser. The Chrome model is an example of what we will see in the days to come. Chrome is nothing but a browser-based environment. It does have some local storage but, by and large, everything is on the

cloud. You have to be online to be able to do anything. This is the direction in which everything is moving. In the long term picture, the desktop OS doesn't really matter. What matters more is your connectivity, access to your data, what you can do with the data and how securely you can access and preserve it to ensure that it is not compromised.

Q How much is Red Hat a part of the Fedora project? Apart from managing the infrastructure and financially supporting it, what say does Red Hat have in designing Fedora?

We have about 20 people who are full time Red Hat employees but work exclusively in the Fedora space. The decision-making about Fedora rests with the Fedora Engineering and Steering Committee, FESCO, which is driven by the community. Red Hat cannot command anything in the project. We have always stuck to very strict principles that the community comes first and business comes second. Yes, we are supporting it and we put money into it in the sense that people are being paid full time salaries to do what they like to do best. In return, we are hoping that our project will be an interesting one for people to participate in. Whether or not we can monetise it in the future is for us to figure out from the Red Hat Enterprise Linux perspective. We can take ideas from Fedora and make them available in RHEL, so that we can officially support that for our customers. Since RHEL is also open source, Fedora is also free to take the best features from it. So this is how the Fedora community and Red Hat benefit from each other. Tomorrow, if Red Hat stops supporting Fedora with finances, the project will still continue, because the community has enough non-Red Hatters to move the project forward. It may fork into different models and different sub-groups, but it will continue.

There is a high degree of cohesion within the group. If you look at the Fedora mailing list, you will find a lot of discussions, counter points and arguments on ways that things can be done in the project. A bulk of those commenting there are community people, who look at Fedora as their own project and there is a sense of personal ownership in the project as well.

Q Do you use Fedora in your personal life as well?

Yes, absolutely! All my systems run Fedora, even the ones at home.

Q What are your comments on Ubuntu's strategy of going retail? Ubuntu joined hands with Dell to set up a retail presence in India and the idea is to increase awareness about the distro. How do you view this move? I can't speak for Ubuntu but I can probably speak as an outsider looking into the scenario. The idea of an open